

ATMOSPHERE

The overall feeling or mood of a scene



1 What is it?

Atmosphere

Atmosphere is the **overall feeling or mood** a piece of writing creates — tense, peaceful, eerie, joyful — built through word choice, setting, and pace working together.

word choice + setting + pace = atmosphere

2 See it in action

Eerie atmosphere

The corridor stretched on in silence, every shadow seeming to shift.

Peaceful atmosphere

Sunlight drifted lazily through the curtains as the house slept.

Tense atmosphere

No one spoke. The clock ticked. Someone shifted in their seat.

Joyful atmosphere

Laughter spilled out of every open window on the street.



Keep going!

Notice the **connotations** of individual words in a description — words with similar meanings can create completely different atmospheres.

FUN FACT

Word connotations do most of the work in building atmosphere — "the house was old" is neutral, but "the house was decaying" instantly creates an unsettling atmosphere with almost the same information.

3 Why writers use it

Atmosphere helps writers: immerse a reader emotionally in a scene before anything explicit happens, prepare a reader for what's coming (dread before danger, calm before change), and make a scene memorable through feeling, not just events.

Atmosphere is built cumulatively — a single word rarely creates it alone, but word choice, sentence length, and setting details working together across several lines certainly can.

4 Don't mix it up!

Atmosphere

- The overall **mood/feeling**
- Built across a whole scene
- How the reader **FEELS** reading it

Setting

- The **time and place** itself
- One tool used to build atmosphere
- **WHERE** and **WHEN** it happens



Watch out!

Don't just say a piece "has a tense atmosphere" — point to the **SPECIFIC** choices (short sentences, ominous word choice, silence) that actually build it.



Mfalme says...

Ask what atmosphere is being built **before** anything actually happens in the scene — that atmosphere often tells you what kind of event is coming.

5 Quick recap

The overall mood of a scene

Built from word choice, setting, pace

Shapes how the reader feels



Look here!

Try describing an empty room twice, using only word choice to make one version feel peaceful and one feel threatening.